

[Return to Search](#)

Original Page: 55

Culture (OWC): [San \(FX10\)](#)

Region: Africa

Sub Region: Southern Africa

Field Date: No Date

Coverage Date: 1950-1970

Place Coverage: G/Wi, Ghanzi District, Botswana

Section Title(S): Conflict • Kinship

In the light of that digression I interpret !Kung ethnography (and my slight acquaintance with !Kung) as one in which antagonistic sentiments were more freely and intensely expressed than within G/wi bands. There were plenty of G/wi with low flash-points and tender vanities but the unguent of close attention was always to hand to comfort the affronted — it was not necessary to stage an impassioned display in order to be heard. Conflict-resolution was a serious pursuit in a band and there were many ways of achieving it. Physical violence was deeply feared and polluting to all who witnessed it. Bruises were the most serious intentional injuries that I saw. These were rare and very shameful. Verbal abuse — exuberant, torrential, and splendidly inventive — sufficed on most occasions. (My observations appear to be at odds with Knauft's [1990:1014] conclusion, “under previous nomadic conditions ... those aggressive incidents which *did* occur were relatively likely to result in death.”) The few obstinately insoluble conflicts that I heard of or saw were construed as being due to the intractability of one of the parties, who was then eased out of the band (see Silberbauer 1981a:173–4). !Kung also had devices for resolving conflicts, but appear as well to have been fairly ready to come to blows. If this did not end the matter, one of the parties would likely move to another camp.

152	Drives And Emotions
157	Personality Traits
184	Cultural Participation
578	Ingroup Antagonisms
627	Informal In-Group Justice
683	Offenses Against The Person

Kinship

Kinship was equally important as an organizing principle for the !Kung as for the G/wi but, although both are universalistic (a characteristic not unique to Basarwa), there were significant differences between the two systems. Terminologically !Kung was of an “Eskimo” type, i.e. parents and children are distinguished from other kin, father from father's brother(s), mother from mother's sister(s), siblings from cousins and offspring from nephews and

184	Cultural Participation
551	Personal Names
601	

nieces. The G/wi terminology was "Iroquois": there was structural equivalence of father's sister and mother's brother and formal equivalence of same-sex siblings. It yielded 56 a small number of distinctive categories, some of which were very broad in their scope. !Kung personal names were gender-specific (32 female names and 36 male names) and were bestowed by rules of kinship — a first-born girl named for her father's mother and a son for his father's father and second children named for the corresponding matrilineal forebears and subsequent ones for father's, then mother's siblings. Shared names implied kinship analogous with the link between oneself and the person for whom one was named. Terminologically the kinship circle was divided into joking, and avoidance-respect categories (a feature common to many peoples around the world, including G/wi). In principle one's name-relationship would accord with the categorization of the person for whom one was named. In practice this resulted in many an *impasse*: potential spouses were placed in a prohibited category, a name-relative would belong to both categories, depending on how one reckoned the link, etc. An overriding principle allowed the senior of the two involved in the jam to define the working kinship category. Lee's discussion (1984:61–73) clarifies what is a complex and wonderfully ingenious system of negotiating the interpretation of rules so as to order relationships coherently.

[Kinship Terminology](#)

602

[Kin Relationships](#)

Human Relations Area Files

755 Prospect Street

New Haven, CT 06511

General Inquiries: [✉ hraf@yale.edu](mailto:hraf@yale.edu)Issues and Bugs: [✉ hraf-support@yale.edu](mailto:hraf-support@yale.edu)[Terms and Conditions](#) · [Accessibility](#) · [Cookie Policy](#)